

LEADING THE CHANGE
Prime Minister Narendra Modi with other senior state leaders at a rally in Jaipur, Sept. 25

doing so, he also curtailed the growing clout of Chandrashekhar, organisational general secretary of the state BJP and the eyes and ears of the central leadership for the past six years, who played a key role in sidelining Raje. The gambit worked, as Raje's assessment of the probable candidates came in handy after the first list of 41 had led to much heartburn. With just two weeks to go for polling, the erstwhile royal was also asked to canvass for the candidates in 49 constituencies. The BJP won 36 of those seats.

Led by Union minister Gajendra Singh Shekhawat, the BJP had also been consistently cornering Gehlot and his government over every possible slip to

AFTER THE POLL DATES WERE ANNOUNCED, MODI ADDRESSED 14 PUBLIC MEETINGS AND LED TWO ROADSHOWS IN RAJASTHAN, HAVING HELD A DOZEN RALLIES IN AS MANY MONTHS BEFORE THAT

build anti-incumbency sentiment on issues ranging from weak law enforcement to inefficiency in implementing central schemes. Though Gehlot could not be directly nailed for corruption, backed by information supplied by Rajya Sabha MP Kirodi Lal Meena—who has now won the Sawai Madhopur seat—the Modi-led Union government tasked central agencies with probing irregularities in various state departments. In their speeches, Modi-Shah seldom missed a chance to mention such allegations against Gehlot, cementing the perception of a corrupt Congress regime in Rajasthan.

The BJP's Hindutva plank also came into play, with the murder of tailor Kanhaiya Lal by Muslim fanatics in Udaipur